



The registry is the place where Windows stores all its settings. These settings are used to control hardware, installed applications, the user interface—practically every setting in the system. So to make any changes to the default settings, the registry has to be edited. To open the registry editor, go to **Start > Run**, type 'regedit' and press [Enter]. The registry editor contains two vertical panes. The left pane has a Windows explorer-like hierarchy structure. Each item here is called key, and a key can have sub-keys. When you select a key, you'll find some items in the right pane. These are the entries corresponding to the selected key. The keys are organised containers for the entries; it is the entries that store the settings. The entries can store different types of data: String, Binary and DWORD values.

■ Back up...back up

The registry is critical for the health of any Windows system. Any damage to it will cause the system to behave erratically. It's recommended that you don't make any changes to the system registry without backing up the current settings. To take a backup of the registry, open the registry editor and select **Registry > Export Registry File**. In the dialog box that appears, select 'All' and enter a name for the backup file. It's also possible to back up specific registry keys. To do so, select the key to be saved, and go to **Registry > Export Registry File**, check 'Selected branch' and click OK.

Windows Me and XP users can create system restore points. This feature lets you revert to a particular state in case of a system crash. To take a snapshot of the current state of the system, go to **Start > Programs > Accessories > System Tools > Sys-**

tem Restore and select 'Create a restore point'. To revert to this point later, you will have to start System Restore and select which point you want to restore to.

■ Creating a new key

To create a new key, just right-click the parent key and select **New > Key**. To create an entry, select the key in the left pane, right-click over in the right pane and select

the data type of the entry to be created.

■ Restart

When a change is made to the registry, the effect may or may not be visible immediately. For example, when changing the title bar text of IE, you need to restart it for the changes to be reflected. For OS-related tweaks you may need to log off and log on again, or even restart the machine.

CUSTOMISATION



ILLUSTRATOR: Farzana Cooper

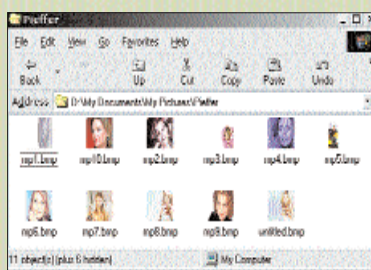
■ Creating icons

The icon of a bitmap file can be set as the file image itself. To effect this setting, navigate to the key **HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT\Paint.Picture\DefaultIcon** and set the value of 'Default entry' to '%1'. Also navigate to the key **HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT/.bmp** and set 'Default entry' to '**PAINT.PICTURE**'. The flip side of this tweak is that folders with a lot of bitmap files might take longer to load. In

such cases, try increasing the icon cache to make the folders load faster. The icon cache can be increased using the 'MaxCachedIcons' entry (type string) in the **HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer** key. Increase the value of this entry to increase the icon cache; use any value between 100 and 4,096.

■ Start Menu scrolling

When your Start menu overflows, it isn't possible to list all the entries in a single column. Then, Windows either creates a second column or a scrolling menu. You can control this through the registry. Navigate to the **HKEY_CURRENT_**



Use bitmap images as icons